when McMahon asked him, and could only come up with an answer the following day and that too using French maps as evidence'.[45]

Furthermore, caution and then neglect on the part of the British rather than 'fear', as the Chinese claim, or secrecy and trickery, according to Maxwell and Lamb, should be seen the reasons why details about the Shimla Convention and the McMahon Line were not released immediately. World War I broke out shortly after the Convention was concluded and Britain obviously had other priorities and was preoccupied with more pressing issues than the demarcation of a border in a remote corner of India.

The fact that Britain did have an agreement with Russia on Tibet should also not be overlooked. It was an important consideration in the corridors of the Foreign Office in London.[46] However, it changed after the Bolshevik revolution in Russia in 1917 and the subsequent establishment of the Soviet Union. The 1907 Anglo-Russian Convention was now definitely dead and buried.

But it is at the same time incorrect to state, as Maxwell, Lamb, and the Chinese have done, that a border along the crest of the Himalayas was not shown on any British or other maps until the 1930s. Watersheds, mountains and rivers divided nations and states long before detailed maps with defined borders became a reality, and the crest of the Himalayas, rather than its southern foothills, has long been a natural dividing line between the Tibetan High Plateau and the Indian subcontinent.

When Charles Bell, the British officer in Sikkim who later took up the post as Britain's envoy to Lhasa, wrote his classic, *Tibet: Past and Present* in 1924, the accompanying fold-out map shows the Indo-Tibetan border at the heights of the Himalayas, or roughly along the McMahon Line.[47] The map of Tibet in *Atlas of the Chinese Empire*, published by the China Inland Mission in 1908, five years before the Shimla Conference, shows the border along the watershed of the Himalayas as well, and so does the map in the March 1912 issue of the *Geographical Journal*, published by the Royal Geographical Society in London. Even some maps printed in China place the border along the crest of the Himalayas. Among them are the official postal map which was used by the government of China in 1917 and a map of Tibet in the *New Atlas and Commercial Gazetteer of China*, published in Shanghai in the same year.[48]